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Leaving the World While Alive

An Interpretive Essay and Documentary Archive on Grigori Perelman's Withdrawal (2005–2026)

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In the name of the Lord of Israel, of Ishmael and of Jesus: whose name is exalted above every name, whose presence keeps our hope alive, who hears our voice in our darkest and hardest hours, and whose grace and mercy bring tears to our eyes despite all our transgressions.

ABSTRACT

This paper approaches the Russian mathematician Grigori Yakovlevich Perelman, who published a proof of the Poincaré conjecture in 2002–2003 and subsequently withdrew from public life after declining the Fields Medal (2006), the Clay Millennium Prize (2010) and candidacy for full membership of the Russian Academy of Sciences (2011), not through his mathematical contributions but through the way of life he chose after leaving mathematics. The paper has two components. The first is an interpretive essay written from the author's own standpoint. It compares Perelman's withdrawal with ترك الدنيا (terkü'd-dünyâ) / פְּרִישׁוּת מִן הָעוֹלָם (perişut min ha-olam) ("leaving the world"), the renunciation practised in the traditions of hermits, priests and monks, and asks: if ascetic traditions draw their strength and meaning from God, what sustains a withdrawal for which the public record shows no religious or metaphysical grounding? The second is a documentary archive that brings together, through explicit source criticism, news reports, photographs and video recordings about Perelman published between 2010 and 2026. The paper also openly addresses the ethical tension inherent in archiving a person who has refused to be put on display, and sets out the principles followed in compiling the archive. It concludes that Perelman's choice can be partly illuminated by religious asceticism, secular *askesis* and the ethos of science, yet cannot be fully reduced to any of them, and that the central question remains open.

Keywords: Grigori Perelman, withdrawal, ترك الدنيا (terkü'd-dünyâ) / פְּרִישׁוּת מִן הָעוֹלָם (perişut min ha-olam), asceticism, ethos of science, Poincaré conjecture, privacy, documentary archive

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1. Introduction

1.1. Why this paper was written

When I first heard of Perelman, what struck me most was his philosophy of life. That a person could reach the very summit of his field, find the most prestigious positions in society laid out before him, and yet refuse all of them for the sake of his moral principles is, in my view, one of the highest stations a human being can attain.

Some believe that mathematics drove him out of his mind; others, that he has reasons he has never shared, whether in print or anywhere else. Whichever is true, Perelman continues to hold to his choice at the time of writing. Who knows: perhaps one day he will decide that the time has come and step in front of the cameras and microphones.

Through this stance Perelman has become a powerful example in our century for many people, myself included. Yet nothing about this exemplary figure has ever been gathered in one place. What is known lies scattered across languages and publications, often beneath sensational headlines. I prepared this paper drawing inspiration from the Satoshi Nakamoto Institute, which collects the writings and correspondence of Satoshi Nakamoto in a single place. My aim is to bring together everything published about Perelman, so that readers can find the most up-to-date news and information about him in one place, and approach it with a critical eye.

1.2. Scope

This paper discusses Perelman's mathematics, and the general biographical information that can be found anywhere, only to the extent needed to establish context. His mathematical work is not examined. What concerns me is what Perelman did after leaving mathematics, and what he continues to do: **leaving the world while alive.** This is what few people are able to do, and what makes Perelman unique.

1.3. Research question

The paper is built around the following question:

> *Why would a person who devoted most of his life to mathematics and reached the summit of his field choose to live as a recluse, renouncing title, fame and wealth; and, unlike in religious traditions of withdrawal, what sustains this choice?*

1.4. Contribution

The paper's contribution is twofold: (i) an interpretive thesis that takes Perelman's withdrawal beyond the framework of "disagreement with the scientific community" that dominates existing discussion, by comparing it with traditions of withdrawal and asceticism; and (ii) an annotated archive that compiles reports from the Russian- and English-language press, specifying for each its date, source type and level of reliability.

1.5. The author's position

This is not a biography that claims neutrality. The author writes as someone deeply affected by Perelman's stance, and approaches the subject, as a reader of faith, through the lens of the traditions of withdrawal. This position is not concealed; on the contrary, it is

declared openly, because the thesis in Section 5 is a direct product of it. In Sections 4 and 6 and in the archive, by contrast, the author's views and what the sources say are carefully kept apart.

2. Method and Sources

2.1. Approach

The paper combines two methods. Section 5 is an **interpretive essay** that does not rely on sources and expresses the author's own reflections. Sections 3, 4 and 6 and the appendices are prepared through **documentary compilation and source criticism**.

2.2. Source types and levels of reliability

Since 2006, Perelman has made almost no direct public statements. As a result, the great majority of what is known about him is second- or even third-hand. Each record in the archive has been assigned to one of the following classes:

	Source type	Example
A	Perelman's own writings, or recorded statements directly attributed to him	arXiv preprints; his statement to Interfax (1 July 2010)
B	Institutional documents	Clay Mathematics Institute press releases; reports on Russian Academy of Sciences procedures
C	Long-form investigative journalism and biographies	Nasar & Gruber (2006); Gessen (2009)
D	Daily press; accounts by third parties such as teachers, neighbours and shop assistants	*Komsomolskaya Pravda*, 78.ru, RIA Novosti
E	Audiovisual recordings (mostly made without his consent)	Footage from shops and streets

Level D records provide information not about Perelman's inner life but about his **outwardly visible behaviour** and **how the media looks at him**. This distinction is maintained throughout the paper.

2.3. Limitations

1. There is no verifiable statement by Perelman himself concerning the period after 2010.
2. A considerable part of the Russian-language press is written in a sensational register; headlines frequently make claims that exceed the content of the article.
3. During compilation, some links could not be accessed for technical reasons (access blocks, mandatory login, timeouts); these records are clearly marked in the archive.
4. The author has not contacted Perelman or his immediate circle and does not intend to (see Section 7).

3. Background: A Brief Chronology

The following chronology provides only the context needed to understand the withdrawal.

Date	Event	Source
13 June 1966	Born in Leningrad.	78.ru (2025)
1982	Gold medal with a perfect score at the International Mathematical Olympiad (Budapest).	78.ru (2025)
1990	Candidate of Sciences (doctoral) degree; researcher at the St. Petersburg Department of the Steklov Institute of Mathematics (POMI).	78.ru (2025)
1992–1995	Worked at the Courant Institute, Stony Brook and Berkeley in the United States; declined permanent offers and returned to St. Petersburg.	78.ru (2025)
1996	Declined the European Mathematical Society prize for young mathematicians.	Vokrug Sveta (2024)
November 2002 – July 2003	Posted on arXiv the three preprints containing the proof leading to the Poincaré and geometrisation conjectures (see Appendix C).	Perelman (2002; 2003a; 2003b)
2003	Gave a series of lectures on his work at several universities in the United States.	78.ru (2025)
2004–2006	Three independent teams worked out the proof in detail and verified it.	Kleiner & Lott (2008); Morgan & Tian (2007); Cao & Zhu (2006)
December 2005	Left his position at POMI; largely cut off contact with colleagues.	78.ru (2025)
June–August 2006	Declined the Fields Medal despite a visit to St. Petersburg by John Ball, President of the International Mathematical Union; did not attend the ceremony in Madrid.	Nasar & Gruber (2006)
August 2006	“Manifold Destiny” published in *The New Yorker*; the dispute over who deserved credit for the proof became public.	Nasar & Gruber (2006)
18 March 2010	The Clay Mathematics Institute announced that it had awarded its first Millennium Prize (US$1 million) to Perelman.	Clay Mathematics Institute (2010)
8–9 June 2010	Did not attend the prize conference in Paris.	Interfax (2010)
1 July 2010	Personally announced to Interfax that he had declined the prize.	Interfax (2010)
2011	The prize money was directed to a position for young mathematicians established by the Clay Institute and the Institut Henri Poincaré. In the same year, Richard Hamilton accepted the Shaw Prize.	78.ru (2025)
October 2011	Did not give the consent required to stand for full membership of the Russian Academy of Sciences.	Izvestia (2011)

Date	Event	Source
June 2016	His 50th birthday; intense press speculation about his private life.	KP (2016a; 2016b)
2022	Rumours that "Perelman has disappeared"; reporters visited his home and refuted them.	KP-Peterburg (2022)
2024	Photographs taken by local residents in a shop were published as the first images of him in years. Richard Hamilton died in September 2024.	KP-Peterburg (2024a; 2024b); KP-Peterburg (2026b)
13 June 2026	His 60th birthday; reported to be still living in Kupchino and not speaking to the press.	KP-Peterburg (2026a; 2026b); Izvestia (2026)
2027 (expected)	Release of Andrey Grigoryev's film about Perelman, *Vitrinny ekzemplyar* ("Showcase Specimen").	KP-Peterburg (2026b; 2026c)

4. Perelman's Own Reasons in the Public Record

Before offering any interpretation, we must look at the words known to have come from Perelman himself, or reliably attributed to him. They are extremely few.

4.1. Direct statement: Interfax (2010)

Perelman personally announced to the Interfax news agency on 1 July 2010 that he had declined the Clay Prize. He said that he had taken a long time to decide, having many reasons both for and against, and stated briefly that the main reason was **"disagreement with the organised mathematical community."** He added that he considered the community's decisions unjust, and that he believed the contribution of the American mathematician Richard Hamilton to solving the problem was no less than his own (Interfax 2010).

This statement is the most solid of Perelman's public reasons (Level A). Two of its elements stand out: (i) the objection is directed not at individuals but at the *organised* community; and (ii) the grievance is not that his own share was too small, but that another person's share was underrated.

4.2. Long-form journalism: *The New Yorker* (2006)

Sylvia Nasar and David Gruber met Perelman in St. Petersburg in the summer of 2006 and placed this encounter within a detailed narrative of the dispute over credit for the proof. According to the article, Perelman expressed his disillusionment with work that claimed credit for his proof without making any new contribution, and with a community that tolerated it; he said he felt that it was not those who violate ethical standards who are isolated, but people like himself who uphold them. Also according to the article, he explained that as long as he was not conspicuous he had the option of staying silent, but that once he became visible, silence was no longer possible for him, and so he had to quit (Nasar & Gruber 2006).

Some of the article's claims were disputed by one of the mathematicians it discussed, Shing-Tung Yau; the magazine stood by its reporting. The article is therefore assessed at Level C: it is the most comprehensive source on Perelman's words, but those words are embedded in a partisan narrative.

4.3. Second-hand testimony

Sergei Rukshin, Perelman's mathematics teacher in his childhood, attributes the withdrawal, as reported in 2026, to two factors: the extreme mental strain of nearly nine years spent on a problem whose outcome was uncertain, and a strict adherence to moral principles (in Russian, *rigorizm*). According to Rukshin, Perelman once insisted on returning to the accounts department surplus grant money that had been paid to him, and told Rukshin that mathematical theorems were **"turning into commodities"** that could be bought, sold and stolen (KP-Peterburg 2026b).

This account is at Level D: Perelman's words reach us not from him but through a third party. Its consistency with the direct statement in 4.1 is nonetheless worth noting.

4.4. Sayings of uncertain origin

A saying attributed to Perelman circulates very widely online, to the effect that he is not interested in money or fame and does not want to be put on display like an animal in a zoo. Its original source could not be reliably identified during compilation. It is therefore mentioned in this paper not as a quotation, but as part of Perelman's public image.

4.5. Interim assessment

Three recurring motifs emerge from the public record:

1. **Fairness:** Credit should be attributed to the right person; Hamilton's share should be acknowledged.
2. **Objection to commodification:** A refusal to turn truth into a commercial value, a prize or an object of ownership.
3. **Refusal of visibility:** A refusal to become a figure, a symbol, a "showcase specimen".

Explanations in the press mostly stop at these three motifs. Yet these motifs answer only the first step of the question *why*. The next section attempts to go beyond that step.

5. Thesis: ترك الدنيا (terkü'd-dünyâ) / פְּרִישׁוּת מִן הָעוֹלָם (perişut min ha-olam)

This section is the author's own interpretation and cites no sources.

5.1. The puzzle

Why does Perelman choose such a life?

Had he been a priest living in the mountains, a recluse absorbed in his books in cells and cellars, or a monk living in caves, what he did would be understandable. But someone who has spent most of his life in mathematics would be expected to want what other mathematicians want: titles and fame. Perelman did the exact opposite. And that is precisely what moved me to write these lines: ترك الدنيا **(terkü'd-dünyâ) /** פְּרִישׁוּת מִן הָעוֹלָם **(perişut min ha-olam), leaving the world.**

5.2. Pressing the question "why?" one step further

You will have read in news reports that the reason was his complaint about the ethical standards of the mathematical community, or that he did not want to be seen as a figure. But why? Why would a person protest the moral values of society, or refuse to be seen as a figure?

My answer is this: **because he has something better within himself in these matters.** What society offers is refused because it falls short of the value he carries within. And what are these better things? They are what is found in recluses, what they seek. Titles, wealth and applause come from outside a person and belong to the outside; what the recluse seeks lies within, something the world cannot provide.

For this reason, reading Perelman's withdrawal merely as "falling out with the community" seems inadequate to me. A person who has fallen out with others usually seeks recognition elsewhere, on another stage. Perelman has stepped onto no stage at all. There is protest in his stance, but beneath the protest lies something deeper than protest.

5.3. The real question: what sustains it?

Yet here another question arises. Recluses, those who have left the world, priests and monks live this life of withdrawal in communion with God; they draw their strength and their motivation from God. For them, withdrawal is not an escape but a turning towards: their distance from the world is the price of their nearness to God.

And Perelman?

In none of Perelman's words or actions that have reached the public do we see a grounding like that of the traditions of withdrawal. All we have is his image and his simple life.

This silence can be read in two ways. The first is that no such grounding exists at all: that Perelman's withdrawal exists purely as a refusal, directed towards no transcendent end. The second is that the grounding exists but, like the withdrawal itself, is kept hidden. If we consider that the true recluse does not display his devotion, and that devotion put on display even loses its worth, then it would be hasty to speak of the absence of something simply because it has not been made public. **That we do not see it does not mean it is not there.**

5.4. Withdrawal in the midst of the world

Another feature that makes Perelman's withdrawal unique is its place. Perelman did not retreat to a mountain, a desert or a cave. He went on living in a working-class district of a metropolis, in an ordinary apartment, among the shelves of a supermarket visited by hundreds of people every day. He withdrew not out of the world, but into its very midst.

This is perhaps the hardest form of withdrawal. The world forgets the monk who retreats to a cave; but the world has not forgotten Perelman. On the contrary, it has waited at his door, filled his mailbox with letters and turned its cameras on him in the shop. His withdrawal is not a solitude won once and then forgotten, but a solitude that must be chosen anew every day.

The saying "die before you die", often invoked in the Sufi tradition, is among the best expressions of the phrase in this paper's title: leaving the world while alive. We do not know whether Perelman knows this saying. But his life is one of the most striking examples we know of what that saying might look like in a modern city.

6. Comparative Framework: Testing the Thesis Against the Traditions

This section is written not to offer an explanation that would replace the thesis of Section 5, but to test it by comparison with known traditions.

6.1. Religious traditions of withdrawal

The Christian tradition. In Late Antiquity, the "holy men" who withdrew into the deserts of Syria and Egypt became, despite their distance from society, or precisely because of it, figures of authority and mediation for that society (Brown 1971). The parallel is striking: Perelman, too, has become a figure whose visibility grows the further he withdraws, and whose silence is read as a message.

The Russian Orthodox tradition. In the fifteenth century, the "non-possessors" (*nestyazhateli*) led by Nil Sorsky opposed the ownership of wealth and land by monasteries and argued that monastic life should rest on poverty and inner prayer (Goldfrank 2008). The link they drew between the renunciation of property and spiritual integrity bears a striking resemblance to Perelman's objection to commodification (see 4.5). Leo Tolstoy's departure from his home at Yasnaya Polyana in 1910, at the age of eighty-two, is likewise a modern instance of the image of renouncing the world in Russian culture.

The Islamic tradition. The concepts of *zuhd* (detaching the heart from the world) and *ʿuzla* (withdrawal from people) lie at the heart of Sufism. In this context, the strongest parallel is al-Ghazali: in 1095, at the height of his career and fame at the Nizamiyya madrasa in Baghdad, he resigned his post and entered a long period of seclusion. In the autobiographical work he wrote later, he attributes this departure to his realisation that fame and position had clouded his intentions (al-Ghazali, *al-Munqidh min al-Dalal*). What al-Ghazali and Perelman share is that each withdrew not after a failure but after a success at the summit.

In all three traditions, withdrawal is not an emptiness but a fullness: the world is left because something more valuable has been found. This lends strong support to the thesis in 5.2. Yet in every one of these traditions, that "more valuable thing" is called by its name: God. In Perelman's case, it is never named. This is exactly where the question of 5.3 arises.

6.2. Is an asceticism without God possible?

The historian of philosophy Pierre Hadot showed that ancient philosophy was a way of life before it was a body of doctrine, and that this way of life rested on "spiritual exercises" that need not be religious (Hadot 1995). The poverty of Diogenes the Cynic, which defied wealth and reputation, or the Stoic principle of valuing only what lies within one's own power, shows that an ascetic life is possible without explicit reference to God. The original meaning of the Greek word *askesis* is, after all, "exercise" or "training".

From this perspective, it could be argued that what sustains Perelman is a devotion to truth itself, raised to an almost sacred value. For a mathematician, truth is the certainty of a proof; Perelman's sharp separation between the worth of a proof and the prize awarded for it can be read as an expression of this devotion.

6.3. Inner-worldly and other-worldly asceticism

Max Weber distinguished between "other-worldly asceticism", lived in withdrawal from the world in the monastery, and "inner-worldly asceticism", lived within the world through one's vocation and everyday life (Weber 1905). Weber's lecture describing science as a "vocation" likewise demands that the scientist devote himself not to personal fame but to the work itself (Weber 1919).

Perelman fits both sides of this distinction and at the same time exceeds both. He has withdrawn from the world, yet he lives in its midst (see 5.4). He devoted himself to his vocation, yet he abandoned it. His case is therefore a borderline case for Weber's categories, perhaps even the proposal of a new one: **an other-worldly life in the midst of the world.**

6.4. The ethos of science: Merton and Bourdieu

The sociologist Robert K. Merton argued that modern science ideally rests on four norms: knowledge as common property, the evaluation of claims by impersonal criteria, disinterestedness, and organised scepticism (Merton 1942/1973). Merton also showed that the history of science is full of priority disputes (Merton 1957) and that recognition flows disproportionately to those already recognised (the "Matthew effect") (Merton 1968).

Perelman's stance can be read as a literal and uncompromising application of these norms. Placing his proof not in a refereed journal but on arXiv, where anyone can read it, is the most extreme expression of the principle of knowledge as common property; declining the prize, of the principle of disinterestedness. Seen from the perspective of Pierre Bourdieu's analysis of the academic field as a competition for symbolic capital (reputation, titles, prizes) (Bourdieu 1984), Perelman is not the one who wins the game but the one who refuses to play it. This framework helps explain why Perelman's objection to the community did not remain a personal grievance but was directed at a *system*.

6.5. Two parallels from within mathematics

Alexander Grothendieck. One of the most influential mathematicians of the twentieth century, Grothendieck left the IHÉS in 1970 in protest at the institute receiving military funding, and in 1991 retreated to a village in the Pyrenees, where he spent the rest of his life in complete seclusion. His long autobiographical text *Récoltes et Semailles* contains a sharp critique of ethical decline in the mathematical community (Grothendieck 2022). Unlike Perelman's, Grothendieck's withdrawal is expressed in an openly spiritual and at times mystical language. This makes Perelman's silence all the more conspicuous.

Satoshi Nakamoto. Satoshi Nakamoto, the inspiration for this paper, likewise published a groundbreaking work openly, then withdrew and left untouched the vast material gain that this work could have brought. The difference between the two figures is that Satoshi withdrew by concealing his identity, whereas Perelman withdrew while his identity was known to all. Perelman's withdrawal is a withdrawal not of hiding, but of standing in plain sight.

6.6. A note on psychological explanations

In the press and in neighbours' accounts, psychiatric labels are at times attached to Perelman (for example, KP-Peterburg 2022). Diagnosing from a distance a person who has never been examined and has not consented is unacceptable both methodologically and ethically. This paper does not use such labels as explanations. The prolonged mental strain mentioned by Rukshin is noted not as a diagnosis but as testimony (see 4.3).

6.7. Assessment

The comparison yields the following result:

- **Religious traditions of withdrawal** explain the *form* of Perelman's behaviour (leaving the world at its summit, renouncing property, silence) with striking accuracy; but to explain what *sustains* it, they require us to assume a faith for which the public record offers no evidence.
- **Secular asceticism and the ethos of science** propose a grounding (devotion to truth, uncompromising fidelity to norms); but whether such a grounding can carry more than twenty years of near-total solitude remains an open question.
- **No framework** suffices to pass definitive judgment on his inner life, as long as Perelman himself does not speak.

The question of 5.3 is therefore not answered in this paper, but it is sharpened: what sustains Perelman's withdrawal is either a secular ethic that holds truth itself to be sacred, or a hidden spirituality that has never been made public. The author's own inclination, as stated in 5.3, is that the second possibility should not be dismissed in haste.

7. Ethical Discussion: Archiving Someone Who Refuses to Be Displayed

This paper carries a contradiction within itself, and it is necessary to discuss it openly.

According to the third of his reasons in the public record, Perelman has refused to be visible and to become a figure (see 4.5). Yet this archive brings together photographs and videos taken without his consent. That the title of the forthcoming film is *Vitrinny ekzemplyar*, "Showcase Specimen", sums up this tension on its own.

There are documented examples of how the press has crossed this line. In 2016, a newspaper itself reported that it had obtained opened private letters addressed to Perelman, which a neighbour had retrieved from the rubbish, and published excerpts from them (KP 2016b). Reporters waiting for him at his home, at the entrance to his building and at the shop where he buys groceries has become a practice repeated over the years (KP-Peterburg 2022; 2026a). One of his teachers has observed that this unhealthy interest in his private life has further reduced his contact with the outside world (KP 2016a).

This paper cannot dissolve that contradiction. It does, however, aim to limit it through the following principles:

1. **Only previously published material.** No new photograph, video or testimony has been added to the archive. The author has not contacted Perelman or his circle.
2. **No location details.** Details of his residence, such as building, floor or door, are not reproduced.

3. **Protection of people who are not public figures.** Details concerning the health and private lives of Perelman's family members are mentioned only at the most general level necessary for context.
4. **Flagging of rumours.** Speculative reports (for example, that he had "disappeared", or claims about plans to marry or have children) are included in the archive not as information about Perelman but as **documents of how the media looks at Perelman**, and are clearly flagged.
5. **No diagnosis.** Psychological or medical labels are not used as interpretation (see 6.6).
6. **Copyright and rights of use.** The rights to all images belong to their respective sources; the source and access date are given for each image.

In light of these principles, the nature of the archive must also be redefined: **this is an archive not only of Perelman, but also of how the world looks at Perelman.** The photographs show less what he is than what the gaze that wishes to see him in this state is. To document a person saying "no" for more than twenty years is also to document what that "no" is said against.

8. Conclusion

Having solved one of the most famous mathematical problems of the twentieth century, Grigori Perelman refused everything that this achievement brought, and since 2005 he has lived in a district of St. Petersburg a life in the midst of the world yet outside it. His limited statements in the public record clearly reveal three motifs: fairness, objection to commodification, and refusal of visibility.

This paper has argued that these motifs are the surface of something deeper: Perelman's refusal of the world's rewards shows that he has found within himself something more valuable than those rewards, and this places him alongside the recluses, priests and monks who have left the world throughout history. Yet in all these traditions, what sustains withdrawal is God, and in the public record there is no trace of such a grounding in Perelman's case. Although secular asceticism and the ethos of science offer a possible answer to this gap, that answer is not conclusive.

Perhaps this is the greatest question Perelman has left us: can a person renounce the world while expecting nothing, and without saying what he relies on, solely for what he believes to be right? Perelman's life seems to answer "yes". But where that "yes" draws its strength from, only he knows.

This paper and its archive will be updated as new records are published.

Appendix A. Audiovisual Archive

This PDF edition does not reproduce the photographs and video recordings of the archive, since the rights to them belong to their respective sources (see Section 7, principle 6). They can be viewed in the online version of this paper at zackha.com/research/archive-on-grigori-perelman. The records are listed below.

Figure 1 (photograph). Portrait of Grigori Yakovlevich Perelman. Source: Heidelberg Laureate Forum, "Grigori Yakovlevich Perelman" (accessed 8 October 2026). Information on the photographer and licence should be verified separately on the source page.

Figure 2 (photograph). Grigori Yakovlevich Perelman. Photograph: Ruslan Voronoy. Source: KP-Peterburg, "Борется с клопами и ездит на электросамокате: Куда пропал и как живет гений математики Григорий Перельман" [Fighting bedbugs and riding an electric scooter: Where the mathematical genius Grigori Perelman went and how he lives] (2022; accessed 14 October 2026).

Figure 3 (video). Footage of Grigori Yakovlevich Perelman shopping in a supermarket in St. Petersburg. Source: 5-tv.ru (accessed 15 October 2026). The source page gives no information on who made the recording or when.

Figure 4 (video). Video recording relating to Grigori Yakovlevich Perelman. Source: 78.ru (18 March 2025; accessed 15 October 2026).

Appendix B. Press Archive (2010–2026)

Records are listed in chronological order. Original Russian titles are followed by an English translation in brackets. The summaries are the author's own and are not translations of the source texts. For levels of reliability, see 2.2. The ⚠ mark indicates records whose content is unverified or speculative.

2010

B1. Interfax — «Последнее "нет" доктора Перельмана» [Dr Perelman's final "no"]

1 July 2010 · interfax.ru/russia/143603 · **Level A**

The statement in which Perelman personally announced that he had declined the Clay Prize and briefly explained why. The most solid source in the public record (see 4.1).

2011

B2. Izvestia — «В Академии наук не смогли понять Перельмана» [The Academy of Sciences could not understand Perelman]

3 October 2011 · iz.ru/news/502731 · **Level B/D**

Report that Perelman did not give, before the deadline expired, the consent required to stand for full membership of the Russian Academy of Sciences.

2016

B3. Komsomolskaya Pravda — «Детей Григорию Перельману может родить суррогатная мать» [A surrogate mother may bear Grigori Perelman's children]

1 June 2016 · Anna Veligzhanina · kp.ru/daily/26537.3/3552917 · Ukrainian edition of the same text: kp.ua · **Level D** ⚠

A report published ahead of his 50th birthday, based on his former teachers: it relates that Perelman was in good health, no longer worked on mathematics, had attended a concert at the Philharmonia, and had stopped after a year of remote consulting for a company in Sweden. The family-planning claim in the headline is attributed entirely to "family acquaintances" and is speculative. The report's value lies in the teachers' testimony it records and in the observation that interest in his private life has reduced his contact with the world.

B4. Komsomolskaya Pravda — «Григория Перельмана завалили любовными письмами» [Grigori Perelman showered with love letters]

13 June 2016 · kp.ru/daily/26541.7/3557842 · **Level D** ⚠ **Example of an ethical breach**

A report in which journalists took opened letters that a neighbour had retrieved from the rubbish and published excerpts from them. It is included in this paper not as a source of information about Perelman, but as a document of how his privacy was violated (see Section 7).

2022

B5. KP-Peterburg — «Борется с клопами и ездит на электросамокате: Куда пропал и как живет гений математики Григорий Перельман» [Fighting bedbugs and riding an electric scooter: Where the mathematical genius Grigori Perelman went and how he lives]

2022 · Photographs: Yuliya Pykhalova, Ruslan Voronoy, Timur Khanov · spb.kp.ru/daily/27442/4645075 · **Level D** ⚠

A report in which, following rumours that Perelman had "disappeared", reporters visited his neighbourhood and spoke with neighbours. It relates that Perelman still lived in the same place, did not collect the gifts sent by admirers, and led a simple life. The neighbours' accounts are largely conjectural. The source of Figure 2.

2024

B6. KP-Peterburg — «Поседевший, в маске и калошах: Математик-затворник Перельман впервые за несколько лет попал на фото» [Grey-haired, in a mask and galoshes: Reclusive mathematician Perelman photographed for the first time in years]

2024 · Stefaniya Barchenkova · spb.kp.ru/daily/27574/4899559 · **Level D/E** ⚠

Photographs taken in a shop by local residents and shared on social media, published as the first images of him in years.

B7. KP-Peterburg — «„Устал в одиночку ухаживать за лежачей мамой": Соседи математика Перельмана рассказали...» ["Tired of caring for his bedridden mother alone": Neighbours of the mathematician Perelman told...]

2024 · spb.kp.ru/daily/27575/4900089 · **Level D** ⚠

A follow-up to B6, based on neighbours' accounts that Perelman alone had taken on the care of his mother.

2025

B8. 78.ru — «Считает каждую копейку и стал вегетарианцем поневоле: как живёт гениальный Перельман» [Counting every kopeck and a vegetarian by necessity: How the genius Perelman lives]

18 March 2025 · Mikhail Kolokoltsev · 78.ru · **Level D**

A comprehensive biographical overview published on the 15th anniversary of the refusal of the Clay Prize. It includes an interview with the school's director, Maksim Pratusevich, accounts from a shop assistant and neighbours, how the prize money was used, and the fact that Hamilton accepted the Shaw Prize in 2011. The source of Figure 4.

B9. RIA Novosti — «Миллион долларов и тихая жизнь в Купчино: история Григория Перельмана» [A million dollars and a quiet life in Kupchino: The story of Grigori Perelman]

10 September 2025 · ria.ru · **Level D**

An overview summarising Perelman's story and including neighbours' accounts.

2026

B10. KP-Peterburg — «Растрепанные волосы, грязные штаны и калоши: Как сейчас выглядит гений-затворник Григорий Перельман» [Dishevelled hair, dirty trousers and galoshes: What the reclusive genius Grigori Perelman looks like now]

June 2026 · Photograph: Aleksandr Dybin · spb.kp.ru/daily/277790/5261504 · **Level D/E** ⚠

A report published ahead of his 60th birthday, in which reporters, after waiting for weeks, photographed Perelman on his way back from the shop.

B11. KP-Peterburg — «Григорию Перельману – 60 лет: Затворник-гений все еще экономит на еде...» [Grigori Perelman turns 60: The reclusive genius still economises on food...]

13 June 2026 · Photograph: Aleksandr Dybin · spb.kp.ru/daily/277790/5262304 · **Level D**

The 60th-birthday report. Alongside the encounter described in B10, it includes the director Andrey Grigoryev's remarks on his film and the teacher Sergei Rukshin's assessment of the withdrawal (see 4.3). An anecdote about Hamilton at a lecture is attributed only to "eyewitnesses" and is unverified.

B12. Izvestia — «Григорию Перельману — 60: почему математик отказался от миллиона долларов и мировой славы» [Grigori Perelman at 60: Why the mathematician turned down a million dollars and worldwide fame]

June 2026 · Yana Chernikova · iz.ru/2112705 · **Level D**

A summary of the proof and the declined prizes, on the occasion of his 60th birthday.

B13. Gazeta.ru — 60th-birthday report

13 June 2026 · gazeta.ru/social/2026/06/13/21297212.shtml · ⚠ **Content unverified**

The page could not be read during compilation because of a mandatory login. The date is taken from the URL.

B14. KP-Peterburg — «Влюбляется в нее и разбивает сердце: Второй тизер фильма о Григории Перельмане...» [Falls in love with her and breaks her heart: The second teaser for the film about Grigori Perelman...]

August 2026 · spb.kp.ru/daily/277805.5/5287579 · **Level D**

A report on the second teaser for the film *Vitrinny ekzemplyar*. The film combines documentary and fictional elements; Perelman is played by the actor Mark Eydelshteyn.

Undated record

B15. Komsomolskaya Pravda — kp.ru/daily/26260.3/3138310

Link · ⚠ **Content unverified**

The page could not be accessed during compilation, so its title, date and content could not be verified.

Appendix C. Perelman's Publications (Selection)

This paper does not examine Perelman's mathematics. For the completeness of the archive, however, his most important publications are listed below.

Preprints leading to the Poincaré and geometrisation conjectures (arXiv)

1. Perelman, G. (2002). *The entropy formula for the Ricci flow and its geometric applications.* arXiv:math/0211159.
2. Perelman, G. (2003a). *Ricci flow with surgery on three-manifolds.* arXiv:math/0303109.
3. Perelman, G. (2003b). *Finite extinction time for the solutions to the Ricci flow on certain three-manifolds.* arXiv:math/0307245.

Selected earlier work

1. Burago, Yu., Gromov, M., & Perelman, G. (1992). A. D. Alexandrov spaces with curvature bounded below. *Russian Mathematical Surveys*, 47(2), 1–58.
2. Perelman, G. (1994). Proof of the soul conjecture of Cheeger and Gromoll. *Journal of Differential Geometry*, 40(1), 209–212.

Perelman never submitted his arXiv preprints to a refereed journal. The proof was verified through detailed works published by other mathematicians (Cao & Zhu 2006; Morgan & Tian 2007; Kleiner & Lott 2008).

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Primary and institutional sources

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Interfax. (2010, July 1). Последнее "нет" доктора Перельмана [Dr Perelman's final "no"]. https://www.interfax.ru/russia/143603

Press sources

All records in Appendix B are cited in the text using the following abbreviations:

78.ru (2025) = B8 · Izvestia (2011) = B2 · Izvestia (2026) = B12 · KP (2016a) = B3 · KP (2016b) = B4 · KP-Peterburg (2022) = B5 · KP-Peterburg (2024a) = B6 · KP-Peterburg (2024b) = B7 · KP-Peterburg (2026a) = B10 · KP-Peterburg (2026b) = B11 · KP-Peterburg (2026c) = B14

Vokrug Sveta. (2024, July 18). Разгадал задачу тысячелетия и отказался от 1 миллиона долларов: как живет сегодня «гениальный отшельник» Григорий Перельман [He solved a Millennium Problem and turned down 1 million dollars: How the "genius hermit" Grigori Perelman lives today]. https://www.vokrugsveta.ru/articles/razgadal-zadachu-tysyacheletiya-i-otkazalsya-ot-1-milliona-dollarov-kak-zhivet-segodnya-genialnyi-otshelnik-grigorii-perelman-id5762714/

Biographical and journalistic sources

Gessen, M. (2009). *Perfect Rigor: A Genius and the Mathematical Breakthrough of the Century.* Houghton Mifflin Harcourt.

Nasar, S., & Gruber, D. (2006, August 28). Manifold destiny: A legendary problem and the battle over who solved it. *The New Yorker.*

Mathematical verification

Cao, H.-D., & Zhu, X.-P. (2006). A complete proof of the Poincaré and geometrization conjectures: Application of the Hamilton–Perelman theory of the Ricci flow. *Asian Journal of Mathematics*, 10(2), 165–492.

Kleiner, B., & Lott, J. (2008). Notes on Perelman's papers. *Geometry & Topology*, 12(5), 2587–2855.

Morgan, J., & Tian, G. (2007). *Ricci Flow and the Poincaré Conjecture* (Clay Mathematics Monographs, Vol. 3). American Mathematical Society.

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al-Ghazali, Abu Hamid. *al-Munqidh min al-Dalal* [Deliverance from Error].

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Source of inspiration

Satoshi Nakamoto Institute. https://satoshi.nakamotoinstitute.org/

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1.0	17 October 2026	First publication.

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